

COURSE SYLLABUS

Success in management requires an understanding of the factors that shape individual and group behaviors and attitudes. This course deals with the people part of management; we will develop a complex view of organizational behavior at the individual, interpersonal, and group levels of analysis. We will examine topics such as motivation, social perception and interpersonal dynamics, influence and persuasion, group decision making, organizational culture and commitment.

The goal is to provide you the tools and concepts to explore why people do what they do and thus, prepare you for management challenges. The course is theory-based but practice oriented. It is firmly grounded in the discipline of social psychology and is designed to focus on the situational causes of behavior, including your own.

The study of people in the workplace is large and complex with no one course able to cover all the important and interesting topics. Because this course is focused on the application of social psychology to help us understand behavior, it is not a traditional Human Resources course. Further, the course is intended to help you manage more effectively, not to give you tactics to improve how others manage you. I encourage you to review the syllabus to see what we will and will not cover to avoid any disappointment.

In addition, we will cover topics related to diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) but with the primary focus being on accurate evaluation of people, for example, employees and job candidates, and the ways our prior beliefs might render our assessments inaccurate. Again, our approach is to determine what social psychology tells us about judgment and behavior with the goal of being a more effective manager. That said, we will not shy away from exploring the role of diversity in organizations, which means we will need to engage in respectful discourse on heated topics. (For more detail, see the section on “Politics versus Education” later in this syllabus.)

Classes consist of lecture, individual and group exercises, case discussion, and other activities that provide opportunities to apply analytical frameworks to concrete organizational problems.

CONTACT INFORMATION:

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-Office hours by appointment - in person or over Zoom
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Teaching Assistants:

- Sam Borislow sbori@chicagobooth.edu
- Anna Brunner abrunne0@chicagobooth.edu
- Graelin Mandel gmandel0@chicagobooth.edu

Sam will be the main TA for the course with Anna and Graelin supplementing his efforts especially around the midterm and final paper. Please copy Sam on all email messages to ensure we are coordinated in our responses and to catch any emergent issues early.

Meeting Times and Locations:

Section 01: Friday, 8:30-11:30a HC C08

Section 02: Friday, 1:30-4:30a HC C08

Section 85: Saturday, 9a-Noon GC 208

Changing Sections. Please note that you may attend another section if a problem comes up, but due to the course format and class sizes, I cannot allow you to register for one section but routinely attend another section.

First class attendance. Students must attend the first class to be/stay enrolled in the course. That first session frames the course material and students who miss it do not get the full benefit of the course. I take attendance the first day and provide the names of missing students to the registrar who cancels those students' registration. For subsequent sessions, I do not take formal attendance but I do grade class participation, which includes showing up for class and engaging in the discussions and exercises.

MATERIALS:**Course website:**

I will post my syllabus, lecture notes and other relevant course information on the course website: <https://canvas.uchicago.edu/>

Required Readings:**1. Required cases and articles:** All cases and articles are available through Canvas.

All readings are required, meaning that you are responsible to know the material in these readings even if they are not explicitly discussed in class. As a general rule, I assume you have read and fully understand the readings assigned for each week. I do not use the lectures to summarize or review the reading material but instead use the lectures to go beyond those readings and focus on new material.

2. Required books: There are two books assigned for the course:

- a. Heath, Chip, & Heath, Dan (2007). *Made to stick: Why some ideas survive and others die*. Random House: New York. ISBN 978-1-4000-6428-1. [Required readings: Introduction, Chapters 1-5.]
- b. Terkel, Studs (1974, with forward from 2004). *Working*. The New Press: New York. ISBN 978-1565843424.

We will read sections from both books, but I encourage you to read each in its entirety when you have the chance. Heath and Heath's *Made to Stick* describes why some ideas succeed in the marketplace of ideas and others fail. We will apply content from the book at two points in the course. In the second week, we will apply context to understand what ideas catch on and how social filters influence and distort the kind of information managers are likely to receive about their employees and the mistaken impressions that are likely to result. Near the end of the course, we will discuss the book again as part of the session on persuasion. Terkel's *Working* is a classic in business publications, is written by a Chicago icon, is enjoyable to read, gives valuable insights into people's working lives, and provides an opportunity to consider similarities and differences in people's underlying motivations and work in the many years since the book was originally published.

3. Lecture notes: I will post .pdf versions of the lecture slides on the course website **after** my Saturday morning session. I appreciate that this policy is unpopular but taking notes is the most effective way to encode and remember course material. I encourage you to take good notes in class and then review them in tandem with the slides afterwards.

COURSE REQUIREMENTS AND GRADING:

Midterm Exam (30%):

The midterm exam, which is in week 6, provides you with the opportunity to demonstrate your knowledge of concepts covered in the first five weeks of the course. It is a closed-note, closed-book exam and will be administered in class. The exam will be roughly ninety-minutes. Sample exam questions are posted on Canvas.

The midterm is meant to distinguish the performance of students who have mastered the material from those who have acquired a superficial understanding. In prior years, the range of performance was very wide. Good performance requires diligent study of the material.

Final Paper (30%):

In lieu of a final exam, I ask that you form a team of three to six members of the class and write a paper applying selected concepts and theories presented in this course to an actual, real-world situation of particular interest to you. One of goals of this course is to improve your team skills, thus I discourage individual and two-person projects. *Special permission must be given for individual and two-person projects and there is a substantial grading penalty for producing such papers (even with permission). See the final paper instructions on Canvas.* Papers should be no more than 10 double-spaced pages and will be due in week 10. More details will be given in class.

Thought papers (30%):

Seven 600-word (max) written assignments provide you with an opportunity to demonstrate that you have completed the readings and considered the personal impact/relevance of selected ideas. These assignments are due at the beginning of class sessions in Weeks 2, 3, 4, 5, 7, 8, 9.

Scores on the thought papers will be 0 (the paper was not submitted), 1 (the paper was superficial and/or seriously conceptually flawed, consistent with lack of engagement of the material), 3 (the paper reflected careful thought about the course material and how it might be applied), and 4 (the paper reflected deep understanding of the course material and the applications described were near perfect examples of the concepts). Note that we will not use a score of 2. Most papers will receive a score of three indicating good engagement with the course material.

This very blunt grading scheme reflects the purpose of these assignments, which is to encourage careful reflection on the course lectures and readings and to encourage you to think about how the course concepts play out in different contexts. These assignments are not primarily intended to assess performance – that is the job of the midterm and final paper. Think of these assignments as akin to basketball practice. While you can be lazy at practice (a score of 1) or be particularly “on” (a score of 4), mostly you go to practice to do drills intended to master skills (a score of 3) that will be of use in the actual game. (This analogy is also intended to reinforce why using AI to complete the assignments is not allowed.)

Please note that we will not give you detailed feedback about these thought papers each week. I encourage you to contact the course TA if you have submitted an unsatisfactory paper that received a score of 1.

Class Participation (10%):

Much of the knowledge you will gain in this class will come from other students—from hearing, evaluating, and discussing ideas presented in the thought papers or during class discussion online. Participation in class is therefore a key component of the learning experience in class, and I expect you to contribute to class discussion whenever you have something interesting and constructive to say. The critical factor, however, is attendance so you can participate in the breakout discussions and exercises. Grading of class participation has a subjective component and the scoring is not subject to regrade requests at the end of the quarter.

Artificial Intelligence Policy

In this course, we will be developing skills and knowledge that are important to discover and practice on your own. Because use of AI tools inhibits development of these skills and knowledge, students are not allowed to use any AI tools at all, including but not limited to ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude, or Grammarly in this course. (For students for whom English is not their first language: Don’t worry, we can read for content, not perfect grammar). Students are expected to present work that is their own without assistance from automated tools. If you are unclear if something is an AI tool, please check with your instructor. Using AI tools for any purposes in this course will violate the Booth Honor Code.

CLASSROOM ETIQUETTE:

Attendance:

One of the goals of this course is to improve your ability to learn from your own experiences and those of your peers; Insight skills are critical to managerial success. You need to show up.

Classroom Technology Policy:

I do my best to create a supportive learning environment. A mutually supportive learning environment depends on active attention and engagement. In addition, as mentioned above, research shows that taking notes by hand instead of typing into a computer leads to better learning. For these reasons and in accordance with Booth's Classroom Technology Policy, the use of laptops and mobile devices is not allowed during classroom sessions. Digital paper tablets or e-ink tablets are allowed.

Exceptions:

Device use for specific activities: There may be occasional in-class exercises, exams, or simulations for which I will explicitly invite you to use your device. I will make these invitations clear at the time.

SDS Accommodations: Students with approved accommodations from [Student Disability Services] that require access to technology are fully exempt from this policy and should use their devices as needed. Please share your accommodation letter with me at the start of the term so I am aware.

Urgent matters: If you are expecting an urgent communication that requires you to monitor your phone during class, please let me know before class begins.

Politics versus Education

This course covers concepts that are very near to active political debates and it takes on "hot button" issues such as diversity and discrimination in the workplace based on social category. For us to do justice to the material and to enhance our understanding of the course concepts, we need to have open and full discussions. That means being respectful of others and allowing people to voice their opinions and to explore their thoughts on the topics without fear of overblown reprisals. That also means expressing our opinions with humility. None of us has full mastery of these topics so our focus is not on condemning or "correcting" people from some self-assured position of greater insight. It also means letting go of any smug, "gotcha" style arguments. Our focus instead will be on exploring the underlying reasoning and information behind our positions and being open to changing our positions based on concepts and data provided in the course. With luck and effort, all of us will think differently and better at the end of this course.

Honor Code:

Students in my class are required to adhere to the standards of conduct in the Booth Honor Code and the Booth Standards of Scholarship. Be sure to sign the following Booth Honor Code Pledge on every assignment: "I pledge my honor that I have not violated the Booth Honor Code during this assignment: _____"

Note that use of large language models, including but not limited to Claude, ChatGPT, Grammarly, and other artificial intelligence tools is forbidden for all assignments and exams in this course.

Accommodations:

If you require any accommodations for this course, as soon as possible please provide me with a copy of your Accommodation Determination Letter (provided to you by the Student Disability Services office) so that we may discuss how your accommodations may be implemented in this course. The University of Chicago is committed to ensuring the full participation of all students in its programs. If you have a documented disability (or think you may have a disability) and, as a result, need a reasonable accommodation to participate in class, complete course requirements, or benefit from the University's programs or services, you are encouraged to contact Student Disability Services as soon as possible. To receive reasonable accommodation, you must be appropriately registered with Student Disability Services. Please contact the office at 773-702- 6000/TTY 773-795-1186 or disabilities@uchicago.edu, or visit the website at disabilities.uchicago.edu. Student Disability Services is located at 5501 S. Ellis Avenue.

COURSE SCHEDULE:

PART I: MANAGERIAL THOUGHT

Week 1: The Power of the Situation

Read before class:

1. Gladwell: Outliers Chapter 1
2. Grant: Think Again Chapter 1
3. Keller: A Tale of Two Plants: NUMMI Teamwork Versus GM Bureaucracy
4. Langfitt: End of the Line for GM-Toyota Joint Venture (supplemental reading to the Keller case)

In class: NUMMI discussion

Prepare:

- First class assignment

Read after class (optional):

5. Senge: The Leader's New Work
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Week 2: Mistaken Impressions: Receiving and Seeking Information

Read before class:

1. Heath & Heath: "Made to Stick" - read Introduction, Chapters 1 – 5.
Note: The material in these chapters is relevant throughout the course but especially this week on information and week 9 on persuasion. I assign the material at this stage to encourage you to get started. Read at least the introduction for class in week 2 and then carry on through the coming weeks, completing the readings by the midterm in week 6.

Submit:

- Complete a background survey (I will send you a link to the online survey)
- Thought paper

In-class Exercise: Carter Racing

Read after class:

2. Snyder and Stukas: Internal Personal Processes: The Interplay of Cognitive, Motivational, and Behavioral Activities in Social Interaction
 3. Kardes and Sanbonmatsu: Omission Neglect: The Importance of Missing Information
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Week 3: Sense-Making: How Beliefs Create Reality

Read before class:

1. Manzoni & Barsoux: The Set-Up-to-Fail Syndrome
2. Banaji, Bazerman, & Chugh: How (Un)ethical Are You?
3. Bohnet and Morse: Designing a Bias-Free Organization
4. Burrell: We Just Can't Handle Diversity

Prepare for case discussion (do not include in your thought paper):

5. Badaracco and Barkan: Ann Hopkins (A)
6. Brief for Amicus Curiae American Psychological Association in Support of Respondent.

Submit:

- Thought paper

Read after class:

7. Heilman and Caleo: Gender Discrimination in the Workplace
8. Snyder: Self-fulfilling Stereotypes

Week 4: Motivation

Read before class:

1. Fishbach: Get it Done Chapters 3 and 4
2. Kerr: On the Folly of Rewarding A, while Hoping for B
3. Pfeffer: Six Dangerous Myths about Pay
4. Selected readings from *Working* by Terkel (further instructions will be sent in an Announcement on Canvas)
5. Optional Reading
 - a. Quinn and Thakor: Creating a Purpose-Driven Organization

Submit:

- Thought paper

In-class Exercise: Motivation at Work

Week 5: Thinking Creatively

Read before class:

1. Amabile, Hadley, & Kramer: Creativity Under the Gun
2. Carnevale: Chapter 19: Creativity in the Outcomes of Conflict
3. Nalebuff & Ayres: Principled Problem Solving
4. **Optional Reading:** Fayard et al.: Nurturing Innovation

Submit:

- Thought paper

In-class Exercise: Individual and group creativity problems

Week 6: Midterm Exam/Your Leadership Brand

Exam – In class

Lecture (after the exam)– Your Leadership Brand

No thought papers or readings for this week. Study for the exam.

Read after class:

Avery and Greenwald: A New Approach to Building Your Personal Brand

PART II: MANAGERIAL ACTION

Week 7: Group Decision Making

Read before class:

1. Janis: Groupthink
2. Harvey: The Abilene Paradox: The Management of Agreement
3. Brett: Negotiating Group Decisions
4. Hammond, Keeney & Raiffa: The Hidden Traps in Decision Making

Submit:

- Thought paper

In-class Exercise (materials distributed in class): Sub-arctic Survival

Week 8: Passive Influence: Culture and Commitment

Read before class:

1. Groysberg et al.: The Leader's Guide to Corporate Culture
2. Pascale: The Paradox of Corporate Culture
3. Collins & Porras: Cult-Like Cultures
4. Tabrizi: How Microsoft Became Innovative Again

Submit:

- Thought paper

In-class discussion: Student descriptions of and experiences with different organizational cultures.

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Week 9: Active Influence: Managerial Persuasion

Read before class:

1. Cialdini: Harnessing the Science of Persuasion
2. Conger: The Necessary Art of Persuasion

Submit:

- Thought Paper

In-class: Case: Henry Fonda in 12 Angry Men

Class	Read before class	Prepare	Hand in	In class
1	1. Gladwell: Outliers Chapter 1 2. Grant: Think Again Chapter 1 3. Keller: A Tale of Two Plants: NUMMI Teamwork Versus GM Bureaucracy 4. Langfitt: End of the Line for GM-Toyota Joint Venture (supplemental reading to the Keller case)	First class assignment		Case: NUMMI Teamwork Versus GM Bureaucracy
2	Heath & Heath: "Made to Stick" – read Introduction, Chapters 1-5 (See note regarding these chapters in the listing of the weekly material above.)	Prepare to discuss Carter Racing Complete online survey	Thought paper	Exercise: Carter Racing
3	1. Manzoni & Barsoux: The Set-Up-to-Fail Syndrome 2. Banaji, Bazerman, & Chugh: How (Un)ethical Are You? 3. Bohnet and Morse: Designing a Bias-Free Organizations 4. Burrell; We Just Handle Diversity	Prepare to discuss: 1. Ann Hopkins (A) 2. Brief for Amicus Curiae APA in Support of Respondent	Thought paper	Case: Ann Hopkins
4	1. Fishbach: Get It Done Chapters 3 and 4 2. Kerr: On the Folly of Rewarding A, while Hoping for B 3. Pfeffer: Six Dangerous Myths about Pay 4. Selected readings from Terkel: Working 5. Optional: Quinn and Thakor: Creating a Purpose-Driven Organization		Thought paper	Exercise: Motivation at Work
5	1. Amabile et al.: Creativity Under the Gun 2. Carnevale: Chapter 19: Creativity in the Outcomes of Conflict 3. Nalebuff & Ayres: Principled Problem Solving 4. Optional: Fayard et al.: Nurturing Innovation		Thought paper	Exercise: Individual and group creativity problems
6	No readings			Midterm Exam Lecture – Leadership Brand
7	1. Janis: Groupthink 2. Harvey: The Abilene Paradox 3. Brett: Negotiating Group Decisions 4. Hammond, Keeney & Raiffa: The Hidden Traps in Decision Making		Thought paper	Exercise: Sub-arctic Survival
8	1. Groysberg et al.: The Leader's Guide to Corporate Culture		Thought paper	Discussion: Class experiences

	2. Pascale: The Paradox of Corporate Culture 3. Collins & Porras: Cult-Like cultures. 4. Tbrizi: How Microsoft Became Innovative Again			
9	1. Cialdini: Harnessing the Science of Persuasion 2. Conger: The Necessary Art of Persuasion		Thought paper	Case: 12 Angry Men

Final Paper Due: Saturday December Dec 12, 2026 5p